

Did I get it Right?

Practising Active Clarification in the Workplace



Name: _____

Date: _____

Activity 1: When “Got It” Isn’t Clear

Think about a time you agreed to something at work but weren’t completely sure what was being said.

Fill in the blanks below

The Situation

The person speaking was my _____
(peer/ manager/client/teammate)

They said something like:

“ _____ ”

The word or phrase that felt unclear was:

“ _____ ”

My Reaction

Instead of asking a question, I said: “ _____ ”
(i.e., “got it”, “okay”, nodded, stayed silent)

The reason I didn’t clarify was:

“ _____ ”
_____ ”

(i.e., “I didn’t want to slow the meeting down”, “I didn’t want to look confused”, “I assumed I could figure it out later”)

Activity 1: When “Got It” Isn’t Clear

Think about a time you agreed to something at work but weren’t completely sure what was being said.

Fill in the blanks below

What Happened Next?

Because I didn’t clarify, the result was:

- ☐ I completed the task incorrectly
- ☐ I had to redo work later
- ☐ Someone has to explain it again
- ☐ The team lost time or momentum
- ☐ Other:

Next time...

If I could do it again, I would:

An example of a clarifying question that could have helped my team is:

ACTIVITY 2:

Practice Active Clarification

In this activity, you'll practice turning unclear instructions into clear understanding using paraphrasing and confirming questions.

Spot the Unclear Language

Many misunderstandings happen because instructions contain vague words.

Read each statement and underline the word or phrase that needs clarification. Then fill in the box with a revised sentence:

1. "Make sure the regional numbers align with the client forcasse before we finalist the deck."

2. "Let's try to wrap up the sprint with all features complete"

3. "We'll need the deck finalized by midweek"

4. "Please make the presentation client-ready before the meeting"



Compare Sheet

Guide sheet with examples and tips included:

Context	Example Phrase	Tone Tip
Peer contributor	"Did we mean bolded or formatted for export?"	Keep it punchy, don't over-polish
Senior manager	"Just to be clear I've got it, would that involve (A) or (B)?"	Honour clarity and time boundaries
Global cross-team	"Would clarification help us avoid surprises later on?"	Use collective phrasing if unsure

Unclear	Clearer
"Sure, got it."	"Just to confirm, that's the updated Q2 list, right?"
"Okay."	"Let me play that back to check I've understood correctly."
- Silence -	"Before I move ahead, are we adjusting scope or timeline, or both?"

Active Clarification Quick Guide

Why Clarification Matters:

In fast-paced workplaces, people often respond quickly with phrases like “got it” or “okay”.

However, agreeing without fully understanding can lead to **miscommunication, rework, missed deadlines and confusion**.

Active clarification helps teams stay aligned and ensures that everyone understand what is expected before taking action.

The Clarification Formula

A strong clarification response includes two steps:

1. Paraphrase – Restate what you understood in your own words.
2. Confirm – Ask a question to check that your understanding is correct.

Example:

Instead of saying “Got it”

Try: “Just to confirm, when you say midweek, do you mean Wednesday end-of-day?”

Helpful Clarifying Phrases

- “Let me check I’ve got this right...”
- “Just to confirm, do you mean...”
- “Quick question, when you say ____, do you mean ____?”
- “Before I move ahead, I want to make sure I understood”



Paraphrasing vs Repeating

Repeating	Paraphrasing
Repeating the same words someone said	Restating the meaning in your own words
"Midweek."	"Do you mean Wednesday end-of-day?"
Shows you heard the words	Confirms you understood the meaning

Clarify vs Challenge vs Correct

Communication Approach	Purpose
Clarify	Confirm meaning and prevent misunderstanding
Challenge	Question or push back on an idea or decision
Correct	Point out that information is inaccurate

Key Takeaway

Clarifying doesn't slow work down, it **prevents mistakes, improves alignment, and builds trust.**

Sometimes **one short question** can save hours of confusion or rework.



Clarify & Connect – A Team Implementation Guide

1. Start with Language Set a weekly theme on Slack: “Clarify with care.” Team members post respectful clarifying phrases they used or appreciated that week.

- **Sample prompt:** “Drop a clarifying phrase you tried this week, no perfection, just progress!”

2. Add it to Team Rituals Use clarification check-ins during meetings:

- “Let’s pause, what are we assuming here?”
- “Before we move on, can someone paraphrase the task?”

3. Make it Visible Post “Phrase of the Week” on digital whiteboards or shared docs.

- **Example:** “Would you mind if I checked my understanding before moving forward?”

4. Peer Accountability Pair up for “clarity buddies”, once a week, teammates reflect briefly:

- “Did either of us clarify something this week?”
- “What impact did it have?”

5. Self or Team Tracking Use a shared Miro board or spreadsheet with a few light-touch indicators:

- “I used a clarifying phrase this week”
- “I encouraged someone else to clarify”
- “We avoided a misunderstanding due to clarification”

Activity prompt: “Which one will you try this week to bring clarification into your team culture?”

Quick Reference: Choosing a Clarifying Phrase

Tone & Context	When to Use It	Example Phrase
Casual / Low-Stakes	Daily team chats, async updates, informal meetings	"Quick check, by 'done,' do you mean dev-complete or live?"
Neutral / Team Norms	Regular meetings, mixed-level contributors, most cross-functional conversations	"Let me check I've got this right, do you mean [X] or [Y]?"
Formal / High-Stakes	Meetings with leadership, clients, high-visibility decisions	"Would you mind if I confirmed my understanding to ensure we're aligned?"
Culture Sensitive / Indirect	Hierarchical settings, global team norms where directness may be discouraged	"To avoid misunderstanding, might we clarify what 'ready' means in this case?"

Tip: You can soften clarification further with framing language:

- "Just to be sure I'm supporting this correctly..."
- "Before I act on that, I'd love to check what you meant by..."
- "Would it help if I restated that in my own words?"

Behavioural Link: Matching your tone to the moment supports psychological safety, and helps others feel more comfortable asking for clarity too.

Clarify vs. Challenge vs. Correct

Clarify: Asking a question or restating something in your own words to make sure you've understood. It's done with curiosity and care, usually to prevent misunderstanding.

- Example: "Just to confirm, do you mean the client call is at 10 or noon?"

Challenge: Pushing back on an idea, process, or decision, often by offering an alternative or disagreement. While sometimes appropriate, this may involve more risk depending on power dynamics.

- Example: "I don't agree with that scope, why are we prioritizing these markets first?"

Correct: Pointing out that something said was inaccurate or wrong. This can feel confrontational unless softened with tone and intent.

- Example: "Actually, that deliverable was already submitted last week."

Tone & Culture Tip:

- In direct communication cultures, these three behaviours may all be appropriate in meetings.
- In indirect or high-context cultures, however, clarification is usually more acceptable than challenge or correction, especially when speaking with a more senior colleague or in a group setting.
 - Learners from indirect communication cultures may feel that even clarification sounds intrusive unless phrased collaboratively
 - e.g., "Would it help to clarify what we mean by Q3 goals?"

Trackable Behavioural Marker Sheet

Behaviour	1 = Not yet	3 = Practicing	5 = Consistent
I used a clarification phrase			
I asked a confirming question before acting			
I noticed improved clarity or understanding			
I felt more confident after clarifying			
I observed a positive shift in how others responded			

Solo Reflection Journal: Practicing Active Clarification

Use this to reflect on how you're building the habit of confirming understanding clearly and respectfully.

Complete after one or more real-world interactions.

Situation Snapshot

- Date/Time:
- Context: (e.g., team meeting, message thread, client call)
- Who was involved?
- What was said or requested?

My Clarifying Response

- What did I say to clarify? (Try to write it out word-for-word.)
- Which phrase or strategy did I use? (e.g., paraphrasing, checking assumptions, softener language)

What Happened Next?

- Did I get clearer on the request?
- How did the other person respond?
- Did it shift the tone, understanding, or trust in the conversation?

Reflection Questions

- How confident did I feel using clarifying language?
- What emotions came up? (e.g., nervous, relieved, awkward, confident)
- How might my style of communication influence others' comfort to clarify?
- If I hadn't clarified, what might have happened?
- What might I try differently next time?

Building the Habit

- What's one phrase I want to keep using?
- When might be a good time to practice again?
- How will I know this habit is making a difference?